



OUR DAILY BREAD

SEEMINGLY ADRIFT IN A SEA OF their own offerings, women devotees remain moored to faith at a temple ceremony in Suryapet, 140 km from Hyderabad. At this Shiva temple, the faithful find themselves lying among rice and flowers offered to the gods by hundreds of devotees.

PATNA | Mofussil Man

Bihar Chief Minister Nitish Kumar hardly has the image of a rebel, but on February 9 in an election year, the JD(U) leader decided to be radical. For the first time, he held a Bihar Cabinet meeting in the style of a village *chaupal* in Begusarai district during the third leg of his "Discovery of Bihar" Vikas Yatra. Kumar's cabinet colleagues and IAS babus were ferried to the village in a luxurious bus in an exercise described as taking the government to the peoples' doorsteps—quite literally. The timing of Kumar's "historic" cabinet meeting was not lost on anyone as it was held on the day UPA Chairperson Sonia Gandhi kick-started an ambitious railway project in another part of Bihar in the company of Railway Minister Lalu Prasad. Babus have maintained a studied silence about the timing of the *chaupal* cabinet, but clearly, this was too close for coincidence. *by Amitabh Srivastava*



KUMAR AND HIS MINISTERS

KUMAR'S CABINET MET IN A BEGUSARAI VILLAGE, LITERALLY TAKING THE GOVERNMENT TO THE PEOPLE.